Cookies and Comfort

A small holiday recipe book



SIGIL AND SCRIBE

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A small holiday recipe book from Sigil and Scribe

Short lists. Forgiving steps. Warm food.

Before you start

Every recipe in this little book is a holiday recipe: the cookies that fill the tin, the casseroles the table waits for, the warm drinks passed around the room. Nothing here is fancy, and nothing here needs to be. These are December dishes, the ones people look for all year.

Short ingredient lists. Forgiving steps. Read the whole recipe once before you start, wash your hands, and let somebody else do the dishes if they offer.

At the back are blank pages for the recipes you want to keep: the ones on index cards, the ones in your head, the ones somebody texted you in a hurry. Write them down before they wander off.

Bake something warm. Share it if you can. Sit down while it is still hot.

Soft Sugar Cookies

You need:

- 1 cup butter, soft
- 1 1/2 cups sugar
- 1 egg
- 1 teaspoon vanilla
- 2 3/4 cups flour
- 1 teaspoon baking soda
- 1/2 teaspoon baking powder
- a pinch of salt
- extra sugar, for rolling

How it goes:

1. Heat the oven to 350 degrees.
2. Stir the butter and sugar together until smooth. Beat in the egg and vanilla.
3. In a second bowl, stir the flour, baking soda, baking powder, and salt.
4. Mix the dry things into the butter bowl until it all comes together.
5. Roll the dough into small balls, roll each ball in sugar, and set them on an ungreased baking sheet.
6. Bake 8 to 10 minutes, until the edges are just set. Cool on the pan a few minutes before moving them.

Note: Soft in the middle is right. They finish setting as they cool.

Gingerbread Cookies

You need:

- 3 cups flour
- 1 teaspoon baking soda
- 2 teaspoons ground ginger
- 1 teaspoon cinnamon
- 1/2 teaspoon ground cloves
- 1/2 teaspoon salt
- 3/4 cup butter, soft
- 3/4 cup brown sugar
- 1/2 cup molasses
- 1 egg
- 1 teaspoon vanilla

How it goes:

1. Stir the flour, baking soda, spices, and salt together in one bowl.
2. In a bigger bowl, beat the butter and brown sugar. Add the molasses, egg, and vanilla.
3. Stir the dry things in until a soft dough forms. Chill the dough at least 1 hour.
4. Heat the oven to 350 degrees. Roll the dough on a floured counter, about 1/4 inch thick.
5. Cut your shapes and set them on a baking sheet.
6. Bake 8 to 10 minutes. Let them cool before moving them; they are tender when warm.

Note: The dough is easier after its rest. So are most of us.

Snickerdoodles

You need:

- 1 cup butter, soft
- 1 1/2 cups sugar
- 2 eggs
- 2 teaspoons vanilla
- 2 3/4 cups flour
- 2 teaspoons cream of tartar
- 1 teaspoon baking soda
- 1/4 teaspoon salt

For rolling:

- 2 tablespoons sugar
- 2 teaspoons cinnamon

How it goes:

1. Heat the oven to 350 degrees.
2. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy. Beat in the eggs and vanilla.
3. Stir the flour, cream of tartar, baking soda, and salt together, then mix them in.
4. Stir the rolling sugar and cinnamon together in a small bowl.
5. Roll the dough into balls about an inch wide, roll each one in the cinnamon sugar, and set them on an ungreased baking sheet.
6. Bake 8 to 10 minutes, until the edges are set and the centers still look soft. Cool a few minutes on the pan.

Note: Makes about 3 dozen. The crackled top is how you know they are right.

Peanut Butter Blossoms

You need:

- 1/2 cup butter, soft
- 3/4 cup peanut butter
- 1/3 cup sugar
- 1/3 cup brown sugar
- 1 egg
- 2 tablespoons milk
- 1 teaspoon vanilla
- 1 1/2 cups flour
- 1 teaspoon baking soda
- 1/2 teaspoon salt
- extra sugar, for rolling
- about 48 chocolate kisses, unwrapped

How it goes:

1. Heat the oven to 375 degrees.
2. Beat the butter and peanut butter together. Beat in both sugars.
3. Beat in the egg, milk, and vanilla.
4. Stir the flour, baking soda, and salt together, then mix them in.
5. Roll the dough into 1-inch balls, roll each in sugar, and set them on an ungreased baking sheet.
6. Bake 8 to 10 minutes, until puffed and lightly golden.
7. The moment they come out, press one chocolate kiss into the center of each cookie. Cool completely so the chocolate can set.

Note: Unwrap the kisses before the cookies go in. The pressing cannot wait.